6.2.3 Alpha decay

A nuclear reaction in which an unstable parent nucleus emits an alpha particle and forms a stable daughter nucleus, is called 'alpha decay'.

E.g.: Decay of uranium (U^{238}) to thorium (Th^{234}) with the emission of an alpha particle.

$$_{92}U^{238} \longrightarrow {}_{90}Th^{234} + {}_{2}He^{4} \quad (\alpha \text{ - decay})$$

In α - decay, the parent nucleus emits an α particle and so it is clear that for the daughter nucleus, the mass number decreases by four and the atomic number decreases by two as illustrated in Figure 6.1

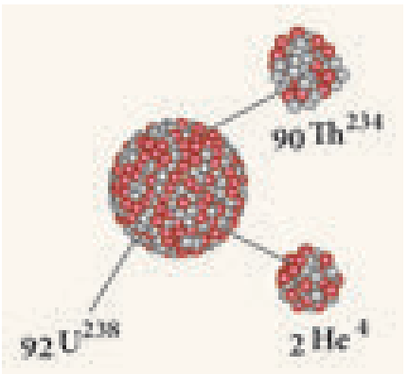


Figure 6.1 Alpha decay

6.2.4 Beta decay

A nuclear reaction, in which an unstable parent nucleus emits a beta particle and forms a stable daughter nucleus, is called 'beta decay'.

E.g.: Beta decay of phosphorous.

$$_{15}P^{32} \longrightarrow {}_{16}S^{32} + {}_{-1}e^{0} \quad (\beta \text{ - decay})$$

In β - decay there is no change in the mass number of the daughter nucleus but the atomic number increases by one.

Note: In a nuclear reaction, the element formed as the product nucleus is identified by the atomic number of the resulting nucleus and not by its mass number.

6.2.5 Gamma decay

In a γ - decay, only the energy level of the nucleus changes. The atomic number and mass number of the radioactive nucleus remain the same.

6.3 NUCLEAR FISSION

6.3.1 Definition

In 1939, German Scientist Otto Hahn and F.Strassman discovered that when a uranium nucleus is bombarded with a neutron, it breaks up into two smaller nuclei of comparable mass along with the emission of a few neutrons and energy. This process of breaking (splitting) up of a heavier nucleus into two smaller nuclei with the release of a large amount of energy and a few neutrons is called 'nuclear fission'.

E.g.: Nuclear fission of a uranium nucleus (U^{235})

$$_{92}U^{235} + {}_{0}n^{1} \longrightarrow {}_{56}Ba^{141} + {}_{36}Kr^{92} + 3\,{}_{0}n^{1} + Q \text{ (energy)}$$

The average energy released in each fission process is about 3.2×10^{-11} J. Nuclear fission is pictorially represented in Figure 6.2.

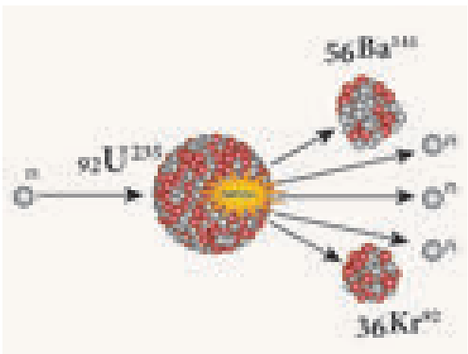


Figure 6.2 Nuclear fission

6.3.2 Fissionable materials

A fissionable material is a radioactive element, which undergoes fission in a sustained manner when it absorbs a neutron. It is also termed as 'fissile material'.

E.g.: U^{235}, plutonium (Pu^{239} and Pu^{241})

All isotopes of uranium do not undergo nuclear fission when they absorb a neutron. For example, natural uranium consists of 99.28 % of $_{92}U^{238}$ and 0.72 % of $_{92}U^{235}$. Of these two, U^{238} does not undergo fission

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